Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you promise care, nature or stability. But green is not a promise for free.

In business green is a peculiar combination. With one hand it holds **health and nature**, with the other **money**. People trust it and watch it at the same time. It promises calm, care and growth, and that is why it is good to know what you promise by it before you let it into a logo, a website or an advertisement.

By itself, though, it does not attract customers like a magnet. It can help create **a trustworthy impression**, but what mainly decides is still what you sell, to whom and how well it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Green can say, for example

"You can take a breath." "It is natural." "You can carry on." "It is all right."

- **Health and nature.** Greenery is linked with what is alive. It suits anywhere you promise freshness, naturalness or health.
- **Calm and care.** It is one of the calmest colours. It speaks of regeneration, a breath and a slower pace.
- **Permission and safety.** "Giving the green light" means permitting. Green in an interface often means "continue" or "it is all right".
- **Money and stability.** Dark green shades feel dignified and stable. Green is linked with money historically too.
- **Sustainability.** Today green is the colour of ecology. A customer expects real actions to stand behind it.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also act differently. A dark forest green is **stable and premium**, sage and mint **gentle and caring**, olive **earthy and crafted**, lime **fresh and bold**.

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Simple tips

- **Shade by role**
  Dark (forest, emerald) for stability and premium feel, fresh spring for health and a new beginning, sage and mint for gentle care and wellness, olive for earthiness and craft.
- **Combinations**
  Cream, white and brown for a natural impression, gold for prestige, powder pink for tenderness.
- **Proof**
  Use the words “bio”, “eco” and “natural” only when you can back them up.
- **Not just for a trend**
  Green “because it is fashionable” gives itself away quickly.
- **Legibility**
  For ordinary text a contrast of at least 4.5 to 1 is recommended (the WCAG accessibility rule). Light green text on a white background is often hard to read.
- **Colour blindness**
  About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Do not use these two colours as the only difference between two things.

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Professions where it is a Yes

Care, healthcare and pharmacies

We link greenery with forest, meadow and rest. A woman in care needs to feel she can take a breath. Green alarms nobody, does not shout and does not press. It speaks quietly, and that is why it suits care. In France a pharmacy has a green cross. Pharmacies used to use a red cross and people confused them with the Red Cross, so a law of 1913 introduced green. Why exactly green is not known precisely.

Healthy food, bio and gardening

Bio, gardening and healthy food can explain their focus quickly thanks to green. Freshness and naturalness is a promise that the customer expects you to keep. Let mainly the products, photographs and materials speak. Green is just their quiet companion.

Coaching, therapy and wellness

A muted green, for example sage or mint, can accompany services focused on balance and regeneration. Try it next to real photographs and natural materials and see whether the result captures your work.

Finance and consulting

A darker green also suits finance and consulting, where you want to seem **stable** and trustworthy. Add cream or gold so that it does not seem too stern.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Dramatic and loud brands.** Nightlife, adrenaline, quick sales (“buy now”). Green here seems too quiet.
- **Luxury in black and gold.** Green gets lost in such a combination. Consider a dark emerald rather as an accessory.
- **Companies that promise naturalness but have nothing to prove it.** Green is a promise. If you do not keep it, the customer notices faster than with another colour.
- **Brands that want to stand out among other greens.** When everyone around uses the same green and you need to be recognisable, look for another shade or another main motif.

Put important information on green areas with well readable contrast. Do not mark success or error by colour alone. Add a word or symbol.

Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the green?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that green means nature and care.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

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Examples from the market

You know green from cafés, petrol stations and shops. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Starbucks (cafés)**
  The original logo of 1971 was brown. After Il Giornale bought Starbucks in 1987, a new logo arose with green and a modified siren. Aha. A change of colour can change how we perceive a brand even when the product stays the same.

- **BP (energy)**
  In 2000 BP introduced the new Helios logo, a sun symbol in green and yellow, and the slogan “beyond petroleum”. Critics later accused it of greenwashing, a green image without matching actions. Aha. Green raises expectations. When actions do not match, disillusionment arises.

- **Heineken (brewery)**
  The beer is typically sold in a green bottle with a red star. In February 2013 Heineken stopped producing brown bottles for the Dutch market and switched to green ones, which it already used for export. Aha. The colour of packaging can become such a strong sign that you recognise it at first sight.

- **John Deere (farm machinery)**
  The first Deere machines got a green frame and yellow wheels sometime between 1870 and 1880 and in 1910 the company decided that all its machines would be marked this way. In 2017 a court confirmed that the combination is a famous trademark. Aha. Green with yellow became a mark of recognition for the company.

What they share is that green carries a simple message. **Nature, care, permission**. And the more it promises, the more has to stand behind it.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, customers and how consistent a brand is. Take it as an idea you will check, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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